

Art of Potential

Between Potential and Ideal - split chapter

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Form, source, canon, and a market that is not the final judge.

The problem art poses to the theory

Art asks whether a living source can become form without becoming extracted style, brand, or raw material. The visible symptoms are markets, canon, museums, AI art, style imitation, prices, appropriation, criticism, and trends. The deeper diagnosis is that the art world fails when the medium that allows a work to appear — market, museum, criticism, algorithm, or canon — begins to behave as if it were the source of value itself.

The artistic ideal is not what is new, famous, expensive, or shocking. It is the form worthy of what seeks to appear. The optimal is how that form can appear within material, body, limitation, history, market, and audience. Source-form-medium map

Living artwork = living source × distance passed through × material discipline × formal risk × witness × context / imitation × overbranding × market as final judge × extraction × erased source × trend.

The map asks: who passed through the distance? How did experience receive form? Who holds, sells, displays, or interprets it? What does the market measure, and what can it never measure?

A model generates “in the style of” a living artist. This is not only a question of formal resemblance. It asks whether another person’s distance has become a neutral reservoir.

A work’s price rises because an institution validated it. Price is visible, but the relation that produced value is not always visible. The market can impersonate the ideal. What art returns to the theory

Art clarifies the grace of relinquishment. Potential that refuses to give up any possibility does not become form. But relinquishment that is not faithful to the source is emptying, not creation. A living work is not the realization of all possibilities; it is a choice that preserves a trace of the whole within a boundary.